ans, there was a sense of déjà vu about many of the resolutions. The Udaipur Chintan Shivir in 2022 had promised similar reforms, including the revival of DCCs, and a 'one person, one post' rule. The 2023 Raipur Plenary reaffirmed these. Yet nothing much changed.

What might distinguish the Ahmedabad session is the immediate follow-up action, particularly the appointment of observers for Gujarat's DCCs and the explicit timeline for implementation. But despite the optimistic tone, the Congress faces formidable challenges. Its organisational structure remains weak, particularly in the Hindi heartland. The party's inability to retain power in states where it won elections post 2014—Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Punjab and Chhattisgarh—points to deeper governance issues that symbolic resolutions cannot easily address.

The party resolutions did bring a sense of déjà vu, but this time there's been follow-up action and timelines set for implementation

The electoral calendar offers little respite, with high-stakes contests in Bihar, Assam, Kerala, Tamil Nadu and West Bengal on the horizon. The party's performance in the state elections, after a relatively good showing in the Lok Sabha poll, has been dismaying, with losses in Haryana, Maharashtra and Delhi.

Perhaps most fundamentally, the Congress still struggles with leadership questions. While the presence of 82-year-old Kharge provides a veneer of non-dynastic leadership, decision-making effectively continues to orbit around Rahul. And the revival efforts he has initiated are by now a budding tradition in themselves: a history littered with well-intentioned declarations withering for lack of action. For the party to be a serious contender in 2029, symbolism must give way to strategy, discipline and grassroots life. Ahmedabad may have provided the blueprint, making it stick remains a daunting challenge. ■

AKALI DAL

Back to Square One

By Anilesh S. Mahajan

Amid the religious chants of "*Jo bole so nihal...*", the Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) re-elected Sukhbir Singh Badal as its president inside the historic Teja Singh Samundri Hall at the Golden Temple complex on April 12. The outcome—backed by 524 newly elected delegates, 467 of them from Punjab—was unsurprising to observers of Sikh politics. Yet for many, it was a disappointment.

For, the re-election and the events leading up to it may have further dimmed hopes of a revival for the century-old party, which has seen its influence in Punjab politics erode dramatically. In December 2024, the then jathedar of the Akal Takht, Giani Raghbir Singh, alongside the heads of four other Sikh seats of authority, had issued a rare *hukumnama* (edict) demanding Sukhbir's resignation. Declaring the SAD leadership "incapable" of addressing Sikh issues, they later appointed a seven-member committee of religious scholars to oversee a fresh membership drive and internal elections. In Sikh tradition, a *hukumnama* carries divine authority, making defiance tantamount to religious disobedience.



PTI

IN THE SADDLE Sukhbir Singh Badal addresses the media after getting re-elected as the Shiromani Akali Dal president in Amritsar, Apr. 12

The edict was seen as a critical opportunity for the SAD to re-set—to reconcile warring factions, reclaim its dwindling support among devout Sikh voters and shed the perception that the party remains a fiefdom of the Badal family. Instead, Sukhbir's return has only reinforced that image. Criticism flowed on cue. Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) leader Harjit Singh Grewal likened Sukhbir to North Korean dictator